

till date including the document name, version, date of creation and even the amount of time spent on it! And under the Document History > Compare Documents, you can do a quick comparison of two or more documents.

The icing on the cake is that AbiWord can read and write various file formats. Its import/export filters include RTF, HTML, OpenOffice.org, Microsoft Word and LaTeX. Another plus point is that the native file format is in XML—thus facilitating the sharing of data across different systems. Note that AbiWord comes in different languages including Hebrew and Arabic! As a matter of fact, it supports right-to-left, left-to-right, and mixed-mode text. AbiWord also supports command—line conversions, printing, and mail-merge.

More importantly, as you can see in the adjoining screenshot, AbiWord uses only around 3 to 6 MB of memory usage while MS Word uses over 10 MB.

6.4.4 Missing Elements

However, two features that are conspicuous in AbiWord by their very absence are—a grammar checker and an ‘Assistant’. A grammar checker is crucial for any MS Word document, AbiWord lacks in this respect, although it has a spell checker. And while some may find the Office Assistant in MS Word distracting, it nevertheless plays an important role. AbiWord needs to incorporate these two features to increase its functionality and popularity.

While it may not match other popular word processors in all aspects, it does offer features that others may lack and is very user-friendly. With a miniscule 5 MB download size, and coupled with the fact that it’s free, AbiWord does make a great alternative word processor.

Tips And Tricks

1. AbiWord plugins are often packaged as bundles, with each bundle comprising import and export plugins that read and write various file and component formats, and the other bundle is